

Veterinary Career Evidence Guide

NAME

DATE

PERIOD

Three members of a veterinary team

All pay figures are **May 2024 U.S. median annual wages**. They are not starting pay and not DFW-local wages. Outlook and openings are national projections for **2024-2034**.

CAREER	WHAT THE WORKER DOES	TYPICAL ENTRY ROUTE	2024 U.S. MEDIAN	2024-34 OUTLOOK	OPENINGS EACH YEAR
Veterinary Assistant or Laboratory Animal Caretaker	Provides routine animal care, prepares equipment, cleans work areas, and supports the veterinary team	High school diploma or equivalent; short-term on-the-job training	\$37,320	9% growth	About 22,200
Veterinary Technician	Performs medical tests, records results, prepares animals and equipment, and assists with treatment under a veterinarian's direction	Usually a 2-year associate degree in veterinary technology; credentialing requirements vary by state	\$45,980	9% growth	About 14,300
Veterinarian	Examines animals, diagnoses illness or injury, treats patients, performs surgery, and protects animal and public health	Doctor of Veterinary Medicine or equivalent professional degree; state license	\$125,510	10% growth	About 3,000

READ THE MEASURES CORRECTLY

- **Median** means half of workers earn more and half earn less. It does not predict a new worker's first salary.
- **Growth rate** describes the expected percentage change in the occupation.
- **Annual openings** includes new jobs and openings created when workers leave the occupation.
- More education can expand responsibility and pay, but it also requires more time, cost, and preparation.

FIRST LOOK

Highest median: Fastest growth: Most annual openings:

Current local pathway evidence

Irving ISD's current public site lists **Veterinary Science at Nimitz High School**. The program page describes Small Animal Management, Large Animal Veterinary Science, and Advanced Animal Science. It also lists several certification opportunities and says the Certified Veterinary Assistant route requires 300 clinical internship hours by the end of senior year.

The *Find Your Future* workbook names Animal Science and Plant Science at Nimitz and describes hands-on facilities and animal-care experiences. Treat the workbook as course context and the current district page as the current program check.

Important boundary: A high-school pathway builds knowledge and experience. It does not make a student a veterinarian or replace the college, professional degree, licensing, or credentialing route listed above.

SOURCES CHECKED AUGUST 8, 2026

- U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Veterinary Assistants and Laboratory Animal Caretakers; Veterinary Technologists and Technicians; Veterinarians. Pay: May 2024. Outlook and openings: 2024-2034.
- Irving ISD, Nimitz High School Veterinary Science program page.

What the numbers do and do not show

Why can the career with the most annual openings have the lowest median pay?

What is one fact you would still need before choosing a route for yourself?
